



BECOMING ORTHODOX

A Journey to the Ancient Christian Faith

by FR. PETER E. GILLQUIST



AUDIOBOOK FOLLOW-ALONG OUTLINE
& ACTION GUIDE

How This Companion Is Built

Becoming Orthodox is the personal account of Fr. Peter Gillquist's twenty-year pilgrimage from evangelical Protestantism — as a senior leader of Campus Crusade for Christ — into the Orthodox Christian Church, eventually leading two thousand fellow evangelicals home with him in 1987. It is part memoir, part church history, part biblical apologetics, and part practical guide for anyone making the same journey today.

This companion organizes the book as a pilgrimage in three movements:

I.	SEARCH	Recognize what's missing in modern Christianity (Chapters 1–4)
II.	DISCOVER	Test every belief against Scripture and the earliest Church (Chapters 5–9)
III.	ENTER	Walk into the historic Church and begin the lifelong journey (Chapters 10–12 + Epilogue)

Part I — The Follow-Along Outline. Chapter-by-chapter, with audiobook timestamps, key stories as memory anchors, the core lesson, and the takeaways. Use this while you listen.

Part II — The "Get Me There" Action Guide. The book's wisdom reorganized as a practical playbook for someone making the same journey. Use this after you finish — or alongside it if you're already on the road.

Visual Guide (separate PDF). A printable framework map and action card to keep on a wall or in a notebook.

PART I

Audiobook Follow-Along Outline

Each chapter below is keyed to its audiobook timestamp and structured the same way: epigraph, key stories (with enough context to use as memory anchors), the core lesson distilled, and the takeaways the chapter is really arguing for. Read along, listen along, or use it as a reference after the fact.

MOVEMENT I

SEARCH

Recognizing what's missing

Four chapters trace the long restlessness — from the boldest days of the 1960s campus revival through a decade of house churches, until seven men sat on a frozen island in 1975 and asked: where is the Church we read about in the New Testament? Are we in hers, or are we still looking?

CHAPTER

1

Never Say Never

The mass conversion that nobody saw coming

AUDIOBOOK MARK 00:00:00

"Now it's your turn to bring America to Orthodoxy. — Fr. James Meena"

Key Stories & Examples

February 1987, St. Nicholas Cathedral (Los Angeles) Metropolitan Philip Saliba ordains 60 former evangelicals to the diaconate and priesthood and chrismates 200 lay people in a four-hour liturgy. "Welcome home," he tells them — and then, to America, "Come home."

Cracking Notre Dame (1965) Gillquist promises the Catholic chaplain he won't proselytize, then packs the convocation center with 2,500 students for two nights. Over 200 commit to Christ. Campus Crusade had "cracked Notre Dame."

The Berkeley Blitz (1966–67) John Braun shuts down a heckler on the steps of Sproul Hall; Billy Graham preaches in the Greek Theater. They engage the radicals on their own turf — and largely lose them within months. The decisions don't stick.

Jack Sparks goes counterculture The Penn State statistics professor swaps a business suit for denim overalls, grows a beard, and outradicalizes the radicals — even baptizing converts in the Berkeley campus fountain. What emerges starts to look less like a parachurch ministry and more like a church.

The Core Lesson

The leaders who would later spend a decade searching for the New Testament Church first had to admit something painful: the campus revivals of the 1960s produced converts but not change. Activity is not the same as fruit. Decisions don't stick without a Church to receive them.

The Takeaways

1. Numerical success can mask spiritual failure — you can win the campus and still lose the world.
2. Parachurch ministry is built on the back of the Church; it cannot replace her.
3. If converts have nowhere to be discipled into a real ecclesial community, most will fall away.



CHAPTER

2

The Phantom Search for the Perfect Church

Christ without church, church without Christ — neither works

AUDIOBOOK MARK 00:09:09

"What we are doing is not working. We are a failure in the midst of our own success."

Key Stories & Examples

A bored teenager in Minneapolis Gillquist grows up Lutheran, becomes president of his church youth group, and confesses to a friend, "I'm not sure I'm even a Christian anymore." The friend answers, "You're miles ahead of me — I don't believe there's a God."

"The sincere milk of the word" After his Campus Crusade conversion, Gillquist takes a friend to a warm Lutheran service. The friend complains there was "no verse-by-verse Bible teaching." Gillquist begins drifting from sacramental worship toward a more privatized, Bible-only faith — which he later realizes is just as incomplete.

The Pipe at Arrowhead Springs Each summer the Crusade regional directors meet at 6 a.m. at Sage's restaurant in San Bernardino to study Scripture together. The Holy Spirit "speaks to us as one man," drawing them back again and again to the question: why aren't we the Church?

The Memphis house church Gillquist's living room fills, then overflows into the backyard. He realizes the gathering has become an outreach event, not a church — communion is sporadic, the spiritual condition of attendees unknown. The hunger for the real Church only grows.

The Core Lesson

Modern American Christianity offers two false choices: church without Christ (dead liturgy and unbelief) or Christ without church (lively faith with no body to live in). Neither will carry you for the long haul. The New Testament knows only Christ-and-Church, inseparable.

The Takeaways

1. Privatized faith — Christ without church — feels alive but eventually starves you.
2. Institutional religion — church without Christ — eventually feels hollow and gets abandoned.
3. The longing for "the New Testament Church" is not nostalgic — it's the Spirit pulling you toward something that still exists.

CHAPTER

3

A Week We Will Not Forget*San Juan Island, 1975 — what the earliest sources actually said*

AUDIOBOOK MARK 00:43:10

*"Israel was liturgical all through its history, and the Church of the New Testament was liturgical from its inception. — Jack Sparks"***Key Stories & Examples**

Worship was liturgical from day one Jack Sparks presents three universally-recognized early sources: Justin Martyr's First Apology (~AD 150), Hippolytus' Apostolic Tradition (~AD 200), and the Didache (perhaps as early as AD 70). All three describe a synaxis-and-eucharist liturgy that looks remarkably like Orthodox worship today.

Bishops in the New Testament John Braun reports that Polycarp of Smyrna, Clement of Rome, and Ignatius of Antioch were all bishops in the first century — Ignatius from around AD 67, in the lifetime of most of the apostles. Acts 1:20 uses *episkopos*; Philippians 1:1 greets bishops by office. The episcopate is apostolic, not a later invention.

Athanasius vs. Arius at Nicaea (AD 325) Richard Ballew traces the church's first great Christological battle. Arius taught that Christ was a created being. The young Athanasius — who had already written *On the Incarnation* at age 21 — became the chief defender. 318 bishops signed the Creed: "there never was a time when he was not."

Gordon Walker takes the Bible While the others divide up worship, history, and doctrine, the Southern Baptist of the group says he'll "check out everything you brothers find against the Bible." The cross-check turns out to be the unity of the project — Scripture and Tradition agree, because they share one Author.

The Core Lesson

When you stop reading modern commentators and go directly to the earliest primary sources — what Christians actually wrote in the first three centuries — you discover that liturgy, sacrament, episcopal government, and Trinitarian doctrine were all there from the beginning. The "primitive simple" church of Protestant imagination never existed.

The Takeaways

1. Liturgy isn't decay — it's the original DNA of Christian worship, traceable to AD 70.
2. Bishops were ordained by the apostles themselves; the office is not a 4th-century invention.
3. The Nicene Creed is the doctrinal fence around the deity of Christ — to step outside it is to lose Him.



CHAPTER

4

Finding the New Testament Church

Following the Church through 1,054 years to the fork in the road

AUDIOBOOK MARK 01:09:40

"I guess that makes us Orthodox."

Key Stories & Examples

The papacy claims supremacy Originally Rome held a primacy of honor — first among equal bishops. Over centuries the popes claimed to be the universal head of the Church on earth, a claim the other four ancient patriarchates (Constantinople, Alexandria, Antioch, Jerusalem) rejected as a departure from apostolic practice.

The Filioque clause (AD 589) King Reccared and a local Spanish council at Toledo unilaterally add "and the Son" to the Creed's confession about the Holy Spirit. Centuries later Rome makes it official, contradicting Christ's own teaching in John 15:26 and changing the universal Creed without an ecumenical council.

The Great Schism (AD 1054) A papal cardinal slaps a document on the altar of Hagia Sophia during the Sunday liturgy, excommunicating the Patriarch of Constantinople. The split is never healed. After 1054, Rome is free to add new dogmas: purgatory, indulgences, papal infallibility (1870), the Immaculate Conception of Mary (1854).

The Reformation fragments the West (1517) Luther nails 95 theses to a church door seeking debate; he's denied an audience and excommunicated. The Western Church shatters. Some retain liturgy and sacrament (Lutherans, Anglicans); others overcorrect into rejection of hierarchy, sacrament, and tradition itself. Division multiplies.

The Core Lesson

The Church remained one for over a thousand years. Rome departed by adding to the apostolic faith; Protestantism departed by subtracting from it. The Orthodox Church alone preserved the New Testament Church into the modern world — about 225 million believers today, but "the best kept secret in America."

The Takeaways

1. Rome added (papal supremacy, Filioque, immaculate conception, papal infallibility); Protestantism subtracted (liturgy, sacrament, hierarchy, Mary, the saints).
2. The seven ecumenical councils (AD 325–787) form a unified deposit of apostolic teaching that any honest seeker can verify.
3. The Orthodox Church is not a denomination — she is the New Testament Church, still here, still Orthodox.



MOVEMENT II

DISCOVER

Testing every objection against the sources

Five chapters work through the biggest evangelical objections to Orthodoxy — tradition, liturgical worship, calling priests "Father," honoring Mary, and the sign of the cross. The pattern is consistent: when you go directly to Scripture and to the earliest Christian sources, the modern Protestant instinct turns out to be the historical anomaly.

CHAPTER

5

The T Word

The two kinds of tradition — and why you need one to keep the Bible

AUDIOBOOK MARK 01:29:47

"Tradition is giving your ancestors a vote. — G. K. Chesterton"

Key Stories & Examples

Two passages that sound contradictory Jesus condemns tradition in Matthew 15 ("you have made the commandment of God of no effect"). Paul commands tradition in 2 Thessalonians 2:15 ("hold the traditions which you were taught, whether by word or our epistle"). The resolution: there are two kinds — the tradition of men and the tradition of God.

Polly Browner's adoption search Adopted as a newborn in 1948, Polly spends her teenage years scanning faces of strangers, looking up Smiths in phone books. On New Year's Day 1976 — after a paper chase through DMV records, banks, and tax assessors — she finally hears her birth mother's voice on the phone. The author offers it as an icon of the spiritual search for one's family of faith.

How the canon was formed The New Testament books weren't sealed by an angel; they were recognized by the Church at the Synod of Carthage in AD 397. The same Holy Spirit that inspired the Scriptures gathered them — using the apostolic tradition as the criterion. To trust the Bible is to trust the Church that gave it to you.

The Jehovah's Witness at the door He has a Bible too. "I believe the Bible" doesn't settle anything if you and your neighbor read it differently. The Church — "the pillar and ground of the truth" (1 Tim 3:15) — is the Holy Spirit's guarantor of the right interpretation.

The Core Lesson

The choice is not Bible vs. Tradition. Scripture is itself part of Holy Tradition — the inspired written part. The same Spirit who inspired the writing also gathered the canon, formed the creeds, and led the councils. To accept one and reject the other is to divide the work of the Holy Spirit.

The Takeaways

1. The tradition of men makes God's Word void; the tradition of God preserves and interprets it.
2. If you trust the Holy Spirit to give you the right Bible, you must trust Him to give you the right Church.
3. Late traditions — Roman additions and Protestant subtractions — are the real enemy, not Holy Tradition itself.



CHAPTER

6

Why We Worship the Way We Do

Five senses, one heaven — Isaiah 6 as the pattern

AUDIOBOOK MARK 01:54:24

"There is just one Divine Liturgy in all the universe — and that's the one in heaven."

Key Stories & Examples

Liturgy in Acts 13 A late-night Bible read in the New American Bible: "While they were engaged in the Liturgy of the Lord and were fasting..." The Greek confirms it — *leitourgeō*, "liturgy." Christian liturgy is in the Bible itself, in Antioch before AD 50.

Isaiah's vision (Isaiah 6) The prophet sees the Lord enthroned, hears seraphim chanting "Holy, holy, holy," smells the smoke of incense, tastes/feels the burning coal that purges his sin, and is sent on mission. Every sense is engaged. Hebrews 8 says Old Covenant worship was patterned after heaven — and heaven, it turns out, looks startlingly like an Orthodox liturgy.

PJ remembering Grandma's house On a final visit before Grandma sells the place, the author asks his 11-year-old son what he remembers. "The smell." Of course Grandma's houses have a smell. So does heaven (Rev 8). So does the Church. Incense is not a quaint extra — it's part of how God's house is built.

"A Christian Lawrence Welk show" An Orthodox priest visits an evangelical Sunday evening service. The preaching is excellent, but the songs are all about "me whose needs are met" rather than the Triune God before whom we bow. Worship has been replaced by Christian entertainment.

The Core Lesson

Worship is not what you make it; it's what you join. There is one Divine Liturgy in the universe — heaven's — and the Church's earthly liturgy is the means by which we participate in it. "Romophobia" — the fear of looking too Catholic — has stripped Protestants of biblical worship that predates Rome by a thousand years.

The Takeaways

1. Worship engages all five senses plus mission; cutting any of them out impoverishes the encounter with God.
2. Spontaneity itself becomes a liturgy — there's no escaping form, only good and bad form.
3. Icons, incense, hymns, sacrament, and altar are all in the Bible — Old and New Testament — long before Rome.



CHAPTER

7

Call No Man Father

Reading Matthew 23 in context — what Jesus actually condemned

AUDIOBOOK MARK 02:22:12

"I in Christ Jesus became your father through the Gospel. — 1 Corinthians 4:15"

Key Stories & Examples

Bing Crosby and Father Flanagan Two of America's most beloved 20th-century icons wear clerical collars and answer to "Father." Yet many evangelicals refuse the title for clergy. The author admits he used to silently apologize to God when he had to use it.

Paul calls himself a father If Matthew 23:9 is taken at face value — never call any man Father — then Paul is in violation in 1 Corinthians 4:15. So is the rich man calling out to "Father Abraham" (Luke 16). So is anyone with an earthly dad. The face-value reading collapses immediately.

The same chapter on "teacher" and "rabbi" Jesus also says don't be called "rabbi" or "teacher" — yet Paul calls himself a teacher of the Gentiles, and Sunday school teachers exist in every Bible-believing church. Clearly Jesus is condemning something other than the title itself.

What the rabbis were actually doing Matthew 23 shows the scribes and Pharisees teaching their own private interpretations as Mosaic law, demanding the best seats, devouring widows' houses, refusing to lift a finger to help. Jesus condemns the abuse of the office, not the office itself. The corrective is not to abolish spiritual fatherhood but to model it on Christ — the only true Rabbi and Father.

The Core Lesson

Jesus was condemning self-exaltation, hypocrisy, and false teaching — not the title "Father." A true spiritual father humbles himself, faithfully passes on the apostles' doctrine, and serves rather than is served. The orthodox practice is not unbiblical; it is the abuse of fatherhood that's unbiblical.

The Takeaways

1. Context matters: read Matthew 23 whole, not as a single proof-text.
2. Paul, Abraham, Sunday school teachers, and your own dad are all immediate counter-examples to the face-value reading.
3. A true "Father" is not above the people — he's the daddy of the household, the one who passes on the deposit of faith faithfully.



CHAPTER

8

Facing Up to Mary

What Scripture actually says about the most blessed of women

AUDIOBOOK MARK 02:39:26

"Henceforth all generations shall call me blessed. — Luke 1:48"

Key Stories & Examples

"We don't give Mary her proper due" Billy Graham himself has said it repeatedly. Modern evangelicalism, in its overreaction to Roman excesses, has effectively erased the woman whom Scripture calls "blessed among women" and "blessed are you among women" — twice.

Theotokos at the Council of Ephesus Nestorius (5th c.) argued that the one in Mary's womb was man but not God. The Church responded: if the one she bore is not God, we are dead in our sins. Calling Mary "Mother of God" / Theotokos is a doctrinal fence around the deity of Christ — denying her title denies His nature.

Mary as the first of the redeemed An icon shows Mary with arms open, Christ alive in her heart. The author is told: this is one of the great evangelistic icons in the Church. Mary was the first person to receive Christ as her Savior; her "let it be to me according to your word" is the prototype of every Christian's response.

The Magnificat as command Mary herself prophesies under inspiration: "henceforth all generations will call me blessed." If your generation doesn't, something has gone wrong — Scripture itself has been disobeyed.

The Core Lesson

Mary is the greatest woman who ever lived, the model for every Christian, the Mother of God incarnate, and the one Scripture commands us to bless. We don't worship her — worship belongs to the Trinity alone — but we honor her exactly as the Bible itself does. To refuse is to disobey.

The Takeaways

1. Mary is the prototype of Christian obedience: "let it be to me according to your word."
2. Theotokos (Mother of God) protects the deity of Christ — it's a Christological doctrine, not a Marian one.
3. Calling Mary blessed is biblical command, not Roman invention. Modern evangelicalism is the historical anomaly.



CHAPTER

9

A Sign for All Christians

The cross as weapon, not decoration

AUDIOBOOK MARK 03:07:52

"God forbid that I should boast except in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ. — Galatians 6:14"

Key Stories & Examples

George Mikan at the free throw line The Minneapolis Lakers' great center crosses himself before a foul shot. Young Pete Gillquist watches from the stands and wonders: is that a rabbit's foot? What is the sign of the cross, anyway?

Tertullian, Athanasius, Cyril — and Luther From the 2nd century forward the sign was universal. Tertullian (~AD 200): "in all our coming in and going out, in putting on our shoes... we mark our forehead with the sign of the Cross." Cyril of Jerusalem: "a powerful safeguard... a terror to devils." Even Luther in his small catechism instructs the faithful to make the sign on rising. It was 17th-century Puritans — not the early Church — who first abolished it.

Blood on the doorposts (Exodus 12) God's people have always used signs of power. The Passover blood on the lintel didn't merely symbolize — it stopped the destroyer. The bronze serpent on the pole healed those who looked. The cross is the New Covenant version: the actual instrument of victory, applied to mind, heart, and strength.

"Romophobia" inventing alternatives After abandoning the historic sign, evangelicals have invented their own — the "One Way" finger of the Jesus Movement, the patriotic hand-over-heart at flag salutes. The body wants to confess what's in the heart. The question is which sign is truly Christian.

The Core Lesson

The cross is not a piece of jewelry; it's a weapon of peace and a confession of power. Every great Christian for 1,500 years made the sign daily; modern evangelicalism is the historical exception. To recover it is to take seriously the Apostle Paul's boast: "the world has been crucified to me, and I to the world."

The Takeaways

1. The sign of the cross was universal Christian practice from the 2nd century — Luther included.
2. Signs in Scripture have power, not just symbolism (Passover blood, bronze serpent).
3. Recovering the sign is recovering an embodied confession of the gospel.



MOVEMENT III

ENTER

Walking into the historic Church

Three chapters plus the epilogue tell the story of the actual entrance — a ten-year courtship, a disastrous trip to Constantinople, an unexpectedly swift welcome from the Antiochian Archdiocese, and twenty-two years of fruit. The journey home was not the end. It was the beginning.

CHAPTER

10

A Decade of Decision*Ten years of meeting the Orthodox Church face to face*

AUDIOBOOK MARK 03:22:58

*"They're Orthodox, but they don't really know it yet. — Fr. Alexander Schmemmann"***Key Stories & Examples**

First contact (1977) John Bartke, a former Berkeley student of Jack Sparks, reads the EOC's draft papers and tells Fr. Alexander Schmemmann at St. Vladimir's: "These things are Orthodox." A phone call to Bishop Dimitri (a former Southern Baptist!) puts Fr. Ted Wojcik on the road to Santa Barbara. The decade of dialogue begins.

Schmemmann's three visits The great Russian theologian comes west three times. He finds bare walls and a pulpit on his first visit; on the second, two postcard-sized icons; on the third, a real altar. He kids the group into Orthodoxy gently — "now I can finally report you're no longer in active opposition to icons."

Bishop Maximus of Pittsburgh A bishop "half-human and half-angel" who hates minimalism, calls his people to deeper commitment, and corrects an Orthodox layman from the lectern when the man says "we don't need to know the Bible." Becomes a lifelong father in Christ to the converts.

The disastrous Constantinople trip (June 1985) \$50,000, twenty bishops, a chartered ferry, hot Ramadan nights — and the Ecumenical Patriarch walks out of the church without speaking to them. They return to Boston with no instructions on how to enter Orthodoxy. Bishop Maximus, sidelined by political pressure from the trip itself, meets them outside Holy Cross to say: don't give up.

The Core Lesson

Finding the true Church is not just an intellectual exercise — it requires meeting actual people, in actual parishes, across cultures you don't yet understand. Doors close. Politics intrude. "Byzantine intrigue" is not a metaphor. But faithful seekers keep knocking, and the Lord eventually opens the right door.

The Takeaways

1. Theology gets you to the doorstep; relationship gets you inside.
2. Cultural difference will feel jarring at first — give it time to feel like home.
3. When one door closes (Constantinople), another opens (Antioch). Don't give up at the first "no."



CHAPTER

11

Welcome Home

Antioch opens her arms — June 1985 to February 1987

AUDIOBOOK MARK 03:55:38

"Brothers, welcome home. — Metropolitan Philip Saliba"

Key Stories & Examples

"Today let's just have fun" Two days after the Constantinople disaster, Bishop John Braun proposes a different approach for the meeting with Metropolitan Philip: drop the gloom, drop the religiosity, just be themselves. "If they like our program, fine. If they don't, that's just fine too." The gloom cloud breaks.

Patriarch Ignatius IV at the Sheraton Universal The fifty-thousand-mile journey ends in a hotel room in Universal City, California. The Patriarch of Antioch and Metropolitan Philip listen for an hour. The Patriarch says: "Let's do everything we can to help them." The Metropolitan says: "This archdiocese makes decisions, and we make them quickly." Within months, the entry is scheduled.

"Bring out the cigars" The 19 bishops arrive expecting a five-minute blessing on the front steps of Englewood. Instead, Metropolitan Philip has set the dining room with linen, china, crystal, and Middle Eastern pastries. "Welcome home." The men can't stop celebrating. Cigars come out. Kathy returns with coffee: "Your Eminence, it's like an opium den in here."

Peggy Thomas's last journey Terminal cancer keeps her from the first chrismation service at St. Michael's. The next week she rides in a van to St. Nicholas Cathedral. "I made it," she tells the author from the back of the vehicle, smiling. She falls asleep in Christ a month later. Metropolitan Philip writes her husband: "sooner or later we will join those whom we love beyond the veils of this temporal existence."

The Core Lesson

When God opens the right door, He opens it wide. The right church is marked by hospitality, decisiveness, and joy. After ten years of seeking, the welcome home was completed in eight weeks — "a series of joyful, glorious, and holy Eucharistic liturgies" across seven North American cities.

The Takeaways

1. When the right door opens, it usually opens fast — God's timing is not the seeker's timing.
2. Hospitality is a mark of the true Church. Genuine welcome is unmistakable.
3. Joy follows obedience. Sometimes overwhelmingly so — like a banquet you didn't know was waiting.



CHAPTER

12

On to the Third Millennium

Each chrismation a little Pentecost — and the call to bring others

AUDIOBOOK MARK 04:28:24

"This looks like a Pentecostal revival."

Key Stories & Examples

St. Michael's Van Nuys (Feb 8, 1987) Glass panels removed, a tent set up for overflow. Juliana Schmemmann flies from New York to witness it. 200 evangelicals chrismated, deacons ordained. "In the classical sense of the term, it was Pentecostal."

The multiple ordination Custom dictates ordaining only one deacon per service — but there are too many. Custom yields to apostolic precedent: "Paul laid hands on them for the grace of the Holy Spirit." The prayer over each new deacon: "plant him in your holy church like a fruitful olive tree."

Seven cities in eight weeks Los Angeles → Santa Cruz → Nashville → Jackson → Memphis → Gary → three Canadian cities → Anchorage → Seattle. Bishop Antoun in Eagle River declares the parish church a cathedral on first sight. Metropolitan Philip flies the route declaring "every experience I had was like a chapter from the Book of Acts."

"Now it's your turn" Metropolitan Philip's commission: Orthodoxy in America has been "the best-kept secret." The 2,000 evangelicals are not received to be quiet about it — they are received to bring America home. The end of the journey is the beginning of the mission.

The Core Lesson

The journey home is not the destination — it is a launching pad. Orthodoxy is not a museum; it is the New Testament Church on mission. Every chrismation is a Pentecost, and every Pentecost has the same end: "Go ye therefore, and make disciples of all nations."

The Takeaways

1. Coming home to Orthodoxy is the beginning, not the end, of the calling.
2. The Spirit confirms the right path with manifest joy and fruit.
3. Mission is not a Protestant invention — it's the original New Testament pattern.



CHAPTER

13

Epilogue — Coming Up on 25 Years

The fruit twenty-two years later

AUDIOBOOK MARK 04:45:33

"The Church has transformed us, affecting us far more than we have affected it."

Key Stories & Examples

The Antiochian Archdiocese doubles From 117 parishes at chrismation to over 250 within twenty years. Plus over 100 new Eastern Rite missions, plus the Western Rite Vicariate, plus dozens of former Anglican and Protestant congregations brought in. The convert wave continues.

The Orthodox Study Bible St. Athanasius Academy produces the New Testament and Psalms, then the complete Old and New Testaments — the first English Septuagint translation in modern use. 450,000+ copies sold. Lifelong Orthodox say it revitalized their faith. Converts say their journey would not have been possible without it.

Conferences and campus ministry The Department of Missions and Evangelism launches an annual conference on outreach (1988); a Canadian counterpart follows (2000). Fr. John Braun rebuilds Orthodox Christian Fellowship on college campuses; today over 270 OCF chapters exist across North America.

Learning to be Orthodox Personal spiritual change: home altars, daily prayer, the saints as friends, the Bible read liturgically rather than academically. "There is an Orthodox sense of Scripture which, honestly, is still dawning on me." The convert is converted, again and again, by the Church he came home to.

The Core Lesson

When God's work is done His way, it bears lasting fruit. Twenty-two years on, the once-improbable wave of evangelical converts has matured into a generation of priests, missionaries, scholars, and parents quietly raising the next generation in the ancient faith. The Church transformed them more than they transformed her.

The Takeaways

1. Long-term fruit, not short-term excitement, is the mark of God-led work.
2. Evangelism and Orthodoxy are not opposites — they're the original New Testament pairing.
3. The Bible is the book of the Church. To read her her way is to receive her at her depth.



PART II

The Get-Me-There Action Guide

A practical playbook for the same journey

If *Becoming Orthodox* is the story of one journey, this section is the playbook drawn from it — the wisdom reorganized as actionable steps any honest seeker can follow, in the same three phases the book itself unfolds: Search, Discover, Enter.

PHASE I

SEARCH

Recognize what's missing

Before you can find the historic Church, you have to honestly admit that something in your current spiritual home is incomplete. The author and his colleagues spent over a decade unable to articulate what they were missing — they only knew that decisions weren't sticking, that worship felt thin, that "the New Testament Church" they read about in Acts wasn't the church they were attending. The first phase is permission to feel that gap honestly.

What To Do

- 1. Audit the gap honestly.** Ask: where is my current Christian life thin? Worship? Sacrament? Continuity? Authority? Don't suppress the question with "my church teaches the Bible." The Jehovah's Witness at your door also has a Bible.
- 2. Reject both false alternatives.** Privatized faith ("Christ without church") feels alive but eventually starves. Institutional religion ("church without Christ") feels hollow and gets abandoned. The New Testament knows only Christ-and-Church inseparably — refuse to settle for either half.
- 3. Stop chasing novelty.** Every new emphasis, conference, movement, or worship style is just another exit from the long road of historic Christianity. The cure for restlessness is not the next new thing — it is the oldest thing.
- 4. Notice what your body is telling you.** Hunger for beauty in worship, for the saints as company, for sacraments that mean what they say, for an authority you can submit to — these are not consumer preferences. They are the Spirit calling you home.
- 5. Be willing to look foreign.** If the New Testament Church has been preserved somewhere, she will not look like 21st-century American evangelicalism. She'll look ancient, eastern, foreign — and that's not a bug, it's the proof.

PHASE II

DISCOVER*Test everything against the sources*

Once you've named the gap, the second phase is the long, slow, occasionally painful work of testing your current beliefs against Scripture and the earliest Christian sources. The seven men on San Juan Island in 1975 made one decision that determined everything else: "if we found we were wrong, we would change." That posture — and only that posture — gets you to the truth. This phase is about going to the primary sources and being willing to be corrected by them.

What To Do

- 1. Read the earliest sources directly.** Justin Martyr's First Apology (~AD 150), Hippolytus' Apostolic Tradition (~AD 200), the Didache (perhaps AD 70), Ignatius of Antioch's seven letters (~AD 107). Don't take a modern commentator's word for what they say. Read them yourself.
- 2. Study the seven ecumenical councils.** Nicaea (325), Constantinople (381), Ephesus (431), Chalcedon (451), Constantinople II (553), Constantinople III (680), Nicaea II (787). They form the doctrinal fence around the apostolic faith. Anything that contradicts them isn't apostolic.
- 3. Sort tradition into two piles.** The tradition of men (man-made, condemned by Christ) and the tradition of God (apostolic, commanded by Paul). Late Roman additions (papal supremacy, Filioque, immaculate conception, papal infallibility) and Protestant subtractions (no liturgy, no sacrament, no hierarchy, no Mary) are both departures from the second.
- 4. Re-read the Bible in the Church's voice.** Stop reading Scripture as a private detective and start reading it liturgically — in the voice of the Church that wrote and gathered it. The Psalms are prayed, not analyzed. The Gospels are journeyed, not dissected. Try the Orthodox Study Bible.
- 5. Address each big objection one at a time.** Tradition (Ch 5). Worship style (Ch 6). "Father" (Ch 7). Mary (Ch 8). The Cross (Ch 9). Don't let an unresolved objection become an excuse. Most evangelical objections to Orthodoxy collapse on contact with the actual evidence.
- 6. Commit in advance to change.** The most important decision is made before the data arrives: "if we found we were wrong, we would change." Without that commitment, study is just self-justification. With it, study is conversion.

PHASE III

ENTER

Take the step home

The third phase is the one most seekers underestimate: actually walking into an Orthodox parish, meeting actual people, and beginning the lifelong journey of becoming Orthodox. The decade of dialogue with the Antiochian Archdiocese taught the EOC leaders that you cannot become Orthodox alone, in your study, from books. You become Orthodox by joining the Church — her people, her rhythms, her sacraments, her culture, her saints.

What To Do

- 1. Visit a parish in person.** Don't audit Orthodoxy from afar. Find a parish, walk in, stay for the whole liturgy, eat the food after. Visit several jurisdictions if you can — Antiochian, OCA, Greek, ROCOR. They are one Church but different cultures.
- 2. Engage the cultural difference with humility.** It will feel foreign at first. Arabic, Greek, Slavonic, ethnic food, ethnic humor. The instinct to flinch is your old self speaking; the instinct to lean in is the Spirit. Learn the people before you critique the culture.
- 3. Find a spiritual father.** A priest who will know you, walk with you, hear your confession, correct you, bless you. Not a guru or a guarantor — a daddy. If you can't find one in your local parish, ask the priest where to look.
- 4. Submit to the rhythms.** Prayer at home morning and evening, with icons. The fasting cycle (yes, all of it). Weekly liturgy. Frequent communion after preparation. The lives of the saints. The Church's calendar will reshape your year — let it.
- 5. Receive chrismation when you're ready.** Not on impulse, not by foot-dragging — when your priest agrees you understand and embrace the faith. Then you are home. The journey is over and the journey is just beginning.
- 6. Become missional.** Orthodoxy is not a museum. The 2,000 evangelicals received in 1987 were sent to bring America to Orthodoxy. You are not received to keep the secret — you are received to share it. Live it visibly. Invite people in. Plant churches where there are none.

Quick Reference

All thirteen chapter takeaways in a single page

Ch 1 — Never Say Never	Activity is not the same as fruit. Decisions don't stick without a Church to receive them.
Ch 2 — Phantom Search	"Christ without church" and "church without Christ" both fail. The New Testament knows only Christ-and-Church.
Ch 3 — A Week We Will Not Forget	Liturgy, sacrament, bishops, and Trinitarian doctrine are all in the earliest Christian sources — not later additions.
Ch 4 — Finding the New Testament Church	Rome added; Protestantism subtracted; Orthodoxy preserved. The Church remained one for 1,000+ years.
Ch 5 — The T Word	Two kinds of tradition: of men (bad) and of God (commanded). Scripture is itself part of Holy Tradition.
Ch 6 — Why We Worship	Worship is not what you make; it's what you join. There is one Liturgy in the universe — heaven's.
Ch 7 — Call No Man Father	Jesus condemned self-exalting hypocrites, not the title "Father." Paul calls himself a spiritual father in 1 Cor 4:15.
Ch 8 — Facing Up to Mary	Scripture itself commands every generation to call Mary blessed. "Theotokos" protects the deity of Christ.
Ch 9 — A Sign for All Christians	The cross is a weapon, not jewelry. Universal Christian practice from the 2nd century — Luther included.
Ch 10 — Decade of Decision	Theology gets you to the doorstep; relationship gets you inside. Don't give up at the first closed door.
Ch 11 — Welcome Home	When the right door opens, it opens wide. Hospitality, decisiveness, joy — marks of the true Church.
Ch 12 — Third Millennium	The journey home is the beginning, not the end. Orthodoxy is not a museum — it's a mission base.
Epilogue — 25 Years	The Church transforms you more than you transform her. Long-term fruit is the mark of God-led work.

"As pre-Orthodox Christians, we had the right Savior — though we've come to know Him better. We had the right Bible, and we have come to know it even better. But we had overlooked that enormous missing factor: the right Church."

— Fr. Peter Gillquist, Epilogue